

# Classic & Modern Poetry: A Cross-Century Conversation

*A curated collection of thematic pairings designed for high school discussion,  
tracing the evolution of Western poetry from 19th-century classics to contemporary responses.*

## Pairing 1: The Reality of Conflict

### The History & Background:

Tennyson was the British Poet Laureate, writing about a disastrous cavalry charge during the Crimean War. He wasn't there; he read about it in the newspaper. He used a driving, galloping meter to make the soldiers' blind obedience sound glorious and heroic.

Sixty years later, Wilfred Owen actually fought in the trenches of World War I. Industrial engineering and chemical weapons had fundamentally changed warfare, and Owen realized Tennyson's rhythmic, heroic style was a lie. Owen wrote "Dulce et Decorum Est" to explicitly attack the old classical ideals, using jagged imagery of gas attacks to show that modern reality required a new, far more brutal type of poetry.

### The Charge of the Light Brigade (Excerpt)

*Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1854)*

Half a league, half a league,  
Half a league onward,  
All in the valley of Death  
Rode the six hundred.  
"Forward, the Light Brigade!  
Charge for the guns!" he said:  
Into the valley of Death  
Rode the six hundred.

"Forward, the Light Brigade!"  
Was there a man dismayed?  
Not though the soldier knew  
Someone had blundered.  
Theirs not to make reply,  
Theirs not to reason why,  
Theirs but to do and die.  
Into the valley of Death  
Rode the six hundred.

### Dulce et Decorum Est

*Wilfred Owen (1920)*

Bent double, like old beggars under sacks,  
Knock-kneed, coughing like hags, we cursed  
through sludge,  
Till on the haunting flares we turned our backs,  
And towards our distant rest began to trudge.  
Men marched asleep. Many had lost their boots,  
But limped on, blood-shod. All went lame; all  
blind;  
Drunk with fatigue; deaf even to the hoots  
Of gas-shells dropping softly behind.

Gas! GAS! Quick, boys!—An ecstasy of fumbling  
Fitting the clumsy helmets just in time,  
But someone still was yelling out and stumbling  
And flound'ring like a man in fire or lime.—  
Dim through the misty panes and thick green light,  
As under a green sea, I saw him drowning.

Cannon to right of them,  
Cannon to left of them,  
Cannon in front of them  
    Volleyed and thundered;  
Stormed at with shot and shell,  
Boldly they rode and well,  
Into the jaws of Death,  
Into the mouth of Hell  
    Rode the six hundred.

In all my dreams before my helpless sight,  
He plunges at me, guttering, choking, drowning.

If in some smothering dreams, you too could pace  
Behind the wagon that we flung him in...  
My friend, you would not tell with such high zest  
To children ardent for some desperate glory,  
The old Lie: *Dulce et decorum est*  
*Pro patria mori.*



## Pairing 2: Observing Nature (and Isolation)

### The History & Background:

Wordsworth was writing at the dawn of the Romantic era. As cities became polluted by the Industrial Revolution, he argued that wandering out into the open nature of the English Lake District was the only way to heal the human soul.

A century later, Rainer Maria Rilke was a young, struggling poet living in Paris. He took a job as a secretary for the famous sculptor Auguste Rodin. Rodin told Rilke he was too emotional and ordered him to go to the Paris zoo, pick one animal, and look at it until he truly understood its physical reality. Rilke chose a pacing panther. Instead of open, healing nature, his poem captures the modern feeling of being trapped in a cage.

### I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud

*William Wordsworth (1807)*

I wandered lonely as a cloud  
That floats on high o'er vales and hills,  
When all at once I saw a crowd,  
A host, of golden daffodils;  
Beside the lake, beneath the trees,  
Fluttering and dancing in the breeze.

Continuous as the stars that shine  
And twinkle on the milky way,  
They stretched in never-ending line  
Along the margin of a bay:  
Ten thousand saw I at a glance,  
Tossing their heads in sprightly dance.

The waves beside them danced; but they

### The Panther

*Rainer Maria Rilke (1902)*

*In the Jardin des Plantes, Paris*

His vision, from the constantly passing bars,  
has grown so weary that it cannot hold  
anything else. It seems to him there are  
a thousand bars; and behind the bars, no world.

As he paces in cramped circles, over and over,  
the movement of his powerful soft strides  
is like a ritual dance around a center  
in which a mighty will stands paralyzed.

Only at times, the curtain of the pupils  
lifts, quietly--. An image enters in,  
rushes down through the tensed, arrested muscles,

Out-did the sparkling waves in glee:  
A poet could not but be gay,  
In such a jocund company:  
I gazed—and gazed—but little thought  
What wealth the show to me had brought:

For oft, when on my couch I lie  
In vacant or in pensive mood,  
They flash upon that inward eye  
Which is the bliss of solitude;  
And then my heart with pleasure fills,  
And dances with the daffodils.

plunges into the heart and is gone.

*(Translated from the German by Stephen Mitchell)*



## Pairing 3: Ruins, Time, and Legacy

### The History & Background:

Shelley wrote "Ozymandias" as part of a friendly sonnet-writing competition. The British Museum had recently acquired a massive, fragmented statue of the Egyptian pharaoh Ramses II. Shelley used the statue to write a warning about the hubris of grand empires and dictators.

Over a century later, Wisława Szymborska (who would eventually win the Nobel Prize) was writing in Poland in the aftermath of World War II. Instead of looking at the giant ruins of kings, she looked at ordinary items in glass display cases. Her poem strips away the grandiosity of history, focusing instead on the quiet, slightly absurd reality that a metal plate or a dress will outlive the person who used it.

### Ozymandias

*Percy Bysshe Shelley (1818)*

I met a traveller from an antique land,  
Who said—"Two vast and trunkless legs of stone  
Stand in the desert. . . . Near them, on the sand,  
Half sunk a shattered visage lies, whose frown,  
And wrinkled lip, and sneer of cold command,  
Tell that its sculptor well those passions read  
Which yet survive, stamped on these lifeless  
things,  
The hand that mocked them, and the heart that  
fed;  
And on the pedestal, these words appear:  
My name is Ozymandias, King of Kings;  
Look on my Works, ye Mighty, and despair!

### Museum

*Wisława Szymborska*

Here are plates with no appetite.  
And wedding rings, but the requited love  
has been gone now for some three hundred years.

Here's a fan—where is the maiden's blush?  
Here are swords—where is the ire?  
Nor will the lute sound at the twilight hour.

Since eternity was out of stock,  
ten thousand aging things have been amassed  
instead.  
The moss-grown guard in golden slumber  
props his mustache on Exhibit Number Eight.

Nothing beside remains. Round the decay  
Of that colossal Wreck, boundless and bare  
The lone and level sands stretch far away.”

Metals, clay and feathers celebrate  
their silent triumphs over dates.  
Only some Egyptian flapper's silly hairpin giggles.

The crown has outlasted the head.  
The hand has lost out to the glove.  
The right shoe has defeated the foot.

As for me, I am still alive, you see.  
The battle with my dress still rages on.  
It struggles, foolish thing, so stubbornly!  
Determined to keep living when I'm gone!

*(Translated from the Polish by Stanisław Barańczak  
and Clare Cavanagh)*